
APOLLON

REVIEWER'S MANUAL 2010

Welcome to *Apollon*!

Thank you for joining our team of editors and reviewers. We have an exciting project, and we hope that you enjoy the work we will share over the course of the coming months together. You should now consider yourself an important part of a team of passionate students and faculty members who strive to promote undergraduate research in the Humanities. Your task as one of the reviewers is not simply to select some papers over others for publication; rather, you will play a significant role in the future of *Apollon* and how it manages to accomplish its mission. Thank you for your involvement. Your contribution is important to us!

Introduction: *Apollon* is an intercollegiate online journal that publishes original undergraduate research in the Humanities. It is a challenge for humanities students, particularly those in small, south-eastern liberal arts colleges and universities, to present their ideas to a large audience beyond their campuses. *Apollon*'s aim is to be the medium through which young and talented researchers can convey their voices to peers and scholars in various institutions across the nation. While we maintain a commitment in particular to featuring schools across the southeast region, we also recognize that digital humanities extends beyond geographic boundaries and we are responding by inviting schools from all regions who share in these principles and goals to join us in this venture. *Apollon* ensures that students at our participating colleges can submit their work for peer-review, and if the paper shows promise and uniqueness, we strive to bring it to light through publication. It might sound simple but publishing a high quality journal of undergraduate academic work is a difficult task. Being part of the Review Board of *Apollon* is not only an excellent opportunity for you to explore the horizons of new and exciting undergraduate research in your field of study, but it is also an effective way of reaching out to undergraduate students like yourself who have the talent and the motivation to make a difference in their respective academic endeavors. As a reviewer, you will have the capacity to accept or reject submissions, or to influence the shape of submissions by seeking anything from minor to substantial changes in their contents and presentation. You will also have the possibility to work directly with the authors on papers you believe have potential but can be improved. It's both an honor and a responsibility. We expect that you will consult with your fellow reviewers or editorial board members on various matters throughout your stay at *Apollon* and make the best use of resources at your disposal.

Peer-Review 360: Peer-review is an essential part of *Apollon*. In fact, it is what defines this e-journal. However, the type of peer-review *Apollon* conducts must not be confused with

what you might have done in the classroom with your classmates. There are several differences which you should be aware of before you take on the task of analyzing a paper and breaking it down to the thesis level. Every submission *Apollon* receives is a polished research paper that has been graded by a faculty member from one of our participating colleges. The minimum grade required for submission is a B+. Moreover, *Apollon* expects without exception that students will revise their works even further beyond the form submitted in the classroom in order to reach a broader audience and to sharpen the argument and research that form the basis for the papers even further. We recommend students to talk to their professors about the areas their research could be improved or ways they can enhance the overall fluidity of their papers which would make them suitable for publication in an e-journal that is in its selection process. As a member of the Review Board of *Apollon*, you should expect to receive well-crafted works of research, and you should respond to them with respect as well as intellectual focus.

Expectations: *Apollon* respects all its members and expects professionalism from its reviewers. All works must be evaluated thoroughly and a decision should be reached *only* after careful dissection of the work. We recognize the effort a student puts into each research paper and value the potential of every submission; we expect you to do the same. To make the process as simple as possible for authors, we encourage our reviewers to complete each assignment (paper) within fourteen days after the paper has been assigned to him/her. If a reviewer fails to meet a deadline, we expect him/her to give adequate reason to an editorial board member for the delay, and we will set another deadline promptly; moreover, we expect prior notification if you believe you will miss a deadline so that the editors can make alternative preparations if the need should arise. We appreciate the work you are putting in for us and we assure you that we will do our best to accommodate your busy schedule; we understand that you might have academic and extra-curricular commitments outside of your work with *Apollon*. Finally, however, we believe that this experience will be rewarding, and we hope you can see that only by putting in a substantial and focused effort will you receive the benefits of deepening your knowledge and experience in digital publication and in forming web-based intellectual communities.

We also expect that you will maintain cordial relationships with your fellow reviewers and editorial board members. Please feel free to ask for suggestions or help if you find it difficult to come to a decision on a paper. If you feel that you might need the assistance of a faculty mentor in the review of a paper, contact the faculty advisor at your college/university and set up an appointment, or ask Dr. Cohen to talk with you if your faculty advisor is not immediately available. Because we expect our reviewers to strive to develop comprehensive understanding in their respective fields of interest, we always promote associations between reviewers and scholars. In the end we understand that peer-reviewing is not an easy task, and we are here to assist you in your task of eliciting the best work from your peers.

The Scope of *Apollon*: *Apollon* is a peer-reviewed humanities e-journal, and thus it

focuses on original academic research in the humanities in conjunction with peer-editing to achieve its mission. We maintain a broad definition of the humanities by including within our purview English, Foreign Languages and Literatures, Music, Theater, History, Classics, Art History, History of Science, Architecture, Philosophy, Religion, Peace and Social Justice, Women's Studies, and regional studies, as well as papers from associated disciplines that engage in humanistic forms of inquiry such as qualitative and theoretical work in Psychology, Sociology, and Anthropology, among others. *Apollon* highlights work produced by undergraduate students, and we maintain a high academic standard for the papers we publish in the belief that undergraduate students from all over the world can acquire tools useful in their own research work by reading papers on the *Apollon* website. However, in its evaluation process *Apollon* utilizes various methods, including but not limited to close-reading of texts, comparative analysis, archival work, and qualitative ethnographic analysis. Due to our digital format, *Apollon* embraces a generous understanding of what constitutes work in the humanities. For instance, a paper that offers an analysis of a public speech or event to convey a philosophical idea can (and should) use audio, image, or video clips to supplement the research. We promote research that creatively and effectively incorporates digital media into traditional research models. We encourage you to keep this in mind that *Apollon* is a digital humanities initiative. In short, at *Apollon* we understand research broadly, and we encourage you to help us envision how the e-journal format can take advantage of our capacity to mount audio files, digital images, video, and text in non-traditional formats.

Authors' Publication Rights: *Apollon* firmly maintains that each paper submitted to *Apollon* remains the sole property of the author, even if the paper is selected for publication. The author reserves the rights to re-publish his/her work at any other journal at any given time after the work has been published in *Apollon*. However, since its focus is on "original" research, *Apollon* holds the right to deny or defer publication of papers or withhold already published pieces if they are found to have been published elsewhere prior to their appearance in our pages. Due to our straightforward submission guidelines and initial review of the materials by editorial board members, we believe it is unlikely that you will come across a paper that violates our policies. But if you do come across a paper that has already been published in any other public venue, including your college's local journals, you should notify the editorial board immediately.

Copyright and Fair Use of Images and Materials in the Public Domain: Textual materials, audio files, images, or videos (print, digital, or otherwise generated) that do not belong to the author can only be used if permission for their usage has been obtained by the author. *Apollon* will not seek to obtain these rights if the author has not secured them already. *Apollon* reserves the right to reject publication of papers or to send them back to the author for revision if they contain copyrighted material not owned by the author or explicitly allowed under an agreement secured by him or her and made available for review prior to publication. We can talk with authors about how to approach the issue of securing rights, but it is common practice for

journals to leave this work to authors, and finally, we cannot undertake this work beyond lending good advice.

Plagiarism: As *Apollon* only considers graded papers that meet the excellent academic standards of our participating schools, we believe that intentional plagiarism should not be a concern during the review process. However, we cannot rule out the possibility that an author mistakenly uses material from other authors without proper acknowledgment or that an author does not uphold the highest standard of citation and acknowledgement of sources. We maintain that such incidents are not malicious, but should be treated fairly and firmly. If plagiarism is discovered, *Apollon* will consult the author about it and will prompt the author to make the appropriate changes for the work to meet the standards of publication. If you find plagiarism of any kind, it is your responsibility to notify the editorial board. Plagiarism includes, but is not limited to, use of copyrighted imagery, audio files, or videos without the proper permission, and use of or paraphrasing of others words or ideas without full citation.

The Review Process

Once you have the research paper in your hands, it's your task to decide whether it meets the standards required and is appropriate for publication in *Apollon*. Before you begin evaluating the work of your peers, we highly recommend that you spend some time researching past issues of *Apollon* or similarly focused journals in the undergraduate humanities to gain a sense of the type of papers we frequently publish. You should always keep in mind that *Apollon* tries to be as broad as possible in its description of the humanities and encourages submission of unconventional yet highly creative research works, such as musicology projects or theatre history, as long as they fit into the our category of original papers that pursue intellectual work. When evaluating each piece of research, be sure to give the author a through hearing before passing a verdict on his/her effort. A good review typically involves at least two close-readings of the text. There are two reviewers assigned to each submission, and the review process usually lasts a month, consisting of two phases. In each phase (not more than 14 days), you should expect to receive 2-3 research papers, each of 2000-6000 words, barring exceptions. If you and your fellow reviewer agree that the paper is fit for publication, then it is assigned for publication. If both of you agree that it is not suitable for publication, then it is usually denied after a last reading by the editorial board members. Otherwise, if one reviewer accepts and the other rejects, or if you both waver on the border, then the editor in chief reviews the paper and decides whether or not to assign it to a third reader.

The following are the areas you must look into before making your decision:

Originality and Breadth of Research: This is perhaps the most important aspect of your review. In your first reading of the author's text, you should outline the creativity and uniqueness in the author's theories as well as in his/her presentation. Consider the argument of the author in light of those of renowned scholars in the same field. You may want to peruse the author's bibliography or brush up informally in the area the paper investigates. We know that this may take additional time and research on your part, but understand that it is also helpful for you in your academic development since your academic interests are more or less closely related to the papers you will receive for evaluation. For instance, you might receive a paper on Shakespeare's play *Hamlet*. There have been thousands of scholars all over the world who have written on *Hamlet*, and you might ask yourself, what can be new about this paper? How does it reconsider earlier arguments, or extend our knowledge in its area of inquiry? It is imperative that you breakdown the author's argument into parts and scrutinize the distinctiveness of the thesis itself. Ask yourself, can this paper shed new light on this classic play. What will my peers in other colleges and universities understand about the play after reading this paper that they could not have understood before it? What is dazzling or surprising here? If you think the author's arguments are trite or are derived from works of others, proceed no further. Also, consider how exhaustive the author has been in his/her research. Are there significant references to well known writers of the same topic? A potentially excellent paper can be marred by the lack of credibility in the author's arguments. If the paper isn't original and comprehensive in its research, then it's in *Apollon's* best interest to not publish it in its present form.

Author's Presentation: Once you are convinced that the paper has unique elements in it and it's mostly well written, it's time for you to dig deeper into the author's writing style and how it complements his/her ideas. A convincingly organized essay can make a good thesis standout, while complacent writing might hinder an otherwise outstanding essay from fully conveying its message. When you read it for the second time, cast a critical eye at the structure of the essay at the paragraph level and pay special attention to topic sentences and at any additional, intentional or unintentional, theses that may or may not support/contradict with the author's original thesis. Note down the author's weaknesses if any. Also, look at his/her sentence and paragraph framing. Is the author able to articulate his/her message to the fullest, or is there still room for improvement? As you analyze the text, you might want to note down any trend you see in the writing, and, at the same time, comment on places you believe are noteworthy or confusing. Your second reading is also an opportunity to ask yourself whether your first impressions were accurate or not. Have your views on the essay changed after inspection with a more critical eye? These would give you a good head-start on to the 2 page recommendation you would submit to the editorial board after finishing the review.

Based on your reading, you will come to one of the following decisions:

Accept – this means that the paper is wholly excellent and should be published on the merits of its research, prose, and insightful analysis. This is a paper that you would be proud to acknowledge in our journal, and it would be a candidate for being judged among the best papers in any class you have taken.

Accept with Minor Changes – this paper has strong moments of excellence, but is lacking some shine or falls into minor problems of prose or argument. These papers are sent back to the author to make certain changes, which should be able to be accomplished quickly and without altering the argument or structure of the paper globally. If the author follows through with the prescribed changes, the paper is guaranteed to be published.

Revise and Resubmit – The paper might be publishable if the author makes more substantial and still manageable changes to it, which might include using more research to frame the argument, re-tooling the introduction or conclusion to reach a larger audience, integrating media files to enrich the appeal of a paper, or restructuring the paper to facilitate its efficiency. Again, these are just some of the examples. A Revise and Resubmit usually means that the paper has the potential to be published in a later issue of *Apollon*, if, of course, the author can make the desired changes and the reviewers are satisfied. Revise and Resubmit decisions, if they are developed into polished essays upon revision, are also guaranteed publication.

Reject – this paper is simply not ready or appropriate for publication. Problems persist at the level of argument, organization, prose, and/or research. It may have an interesting idea at its core, but that idea cannot be presented in the current manner, or with the current set of claims and analyses. We have pre-selected papers to eliminate the least publishable already, and thus we hope not to send out too many of these, but given the nature of a selective journal we expect to have a rejection rate of roughly 50% or more (at least to begin, and this may go up).

Comments: Each of you bring your own experiences and expertise to *Apollon* and we are interested in hearing your feedback. So, this is a chance to be candid, insightful, and thorough in your comments. The comments section should provide the rationale for your decision to make one of the four choices above. We expect your comments to be to the point yet capacious in their analysis. You should write about 1000 words (two pages single spaced) underscoring the reasons behind your decision to accept or reject the paper. If you have decided to accept the paper with minor changes or send it back to the author for revision and resubmission, we ask that you clearly point out the changes you deem necessary to make the essay publishable. You should indicate page numbers, sentences, ideas, and arguments: we want you to move between general questions and particular observations freely. We request you to be especially careful when you

choose to accept the paper with minor edits, as it guarantees the author publication if your dictated steps are accurately followed. You should point out areas of improvement in the text, so the author can work on them without having to revise the work substantially. Also, keep in mind that the author will have roughly three weeks to respond to your requests, and that *Apollon* strives to maximize the completion rate of accept with minor changes and revise and resubmit requests.

Working with the Author: If at any point in your review, you would like to work with the author on improving his/her paper, please make a request to the editorial board. Papers are usually reviewed anonymously. If the author requests (after you have submitted your recommendation) to work with you, it is up to you whether you want to work with him/her or not. There are certain things you should keep in mind if you decide to work with the author. First, always remember that you are not required to correspond with the author if not necessary. However, if the author is interested in making the changes you pointed out, you should consider helping the author *understand* your recommendations better.

Working with other Reviewers: Each of you will be given the contact information of all the other reviewers working for *Apollon*. We highly encourage our reviewers to correspond with one another at various stages throughout the review process. At any point, if you feel that a particular essay could be improved but you are not confident how, please feel free to talk to your peers in *Apollon*. We hope that you will also be willing to help other reviewers when they ask for your suggestions. We are currently working toward setting up a discussion forum in our website to facilitate better interactions between our reviewers and editorial board members. Once again, *Apollon* is all about peer-editing and we hope working with others will be a rewarding experience for all of you.

Copy-editing

Although copyediting may seem like a mundane task, it is a vital part of the review process. Proper copyediting can add more vibe to an already strong essay, and it is an essential component of an e-journal like *Apollon* that aims for excellence in quality. **Note: You will only be doing copyediting for papers that have been accepted for publication.**

Checklist and Tips:

Typos: Concentrate on individual words rather than whole sentences during close reading of the text. Take a break between paragraphs and read each word out loud. Sometimes you will “hear” the mistakes you cannot see.

Missing Words or Sentences. Omitting words or even sentences is a very common error. Reading the sentences aloud also helps here; if there is a missing word, the sentence will seem awkward.

Punctuations or Apposition: Read carefully to see whether punctuations are missing or are misplaced. Check to see if there are unclear pronoun or verb references or unintentional sentence fragments.

Citations and formatting: Look closely whether the sources are properly cited and whether there are any missing quotation marks.

Dates: A 1960 instead of 1090 can make a significant difference to a text. Check each date to ensure that everything makes sense and that the author has not mistakenly put down a wrong date.

Review: Use the Review tool in Microsoft Word to check for spelling and grammar errors. Often computer catches the mistakes that the eyes cannot!

Treat each sentence as an individual unit. Does the sentence stand up on its own? Is subject-verb agreement tight? Make sure these units of meaning convey their purposes well.

Grammar Rules: Spend some time in each review period sharpening or revising your major grammar skills: consider word order, parallelism, pronoun use, coordinating words, and so on. Read slowly. Even expert grammarians need practice.

Point out single words and examine whether they are the most precise ones available: Focusing on a single word enhances your concentration on the paper as a whole. Often the single word is the most important factor to consider when detecting errors.

Review all internet links in the article: Just copy and paste them in your browser to make sure that they are correct and free of broken links.

If you come across portions in texts in which you are not sure what the author meant to do, please contact the editorial board and ask them for help.

Reference Books: You should be able to find each of the following grammar and proofreading books in your library or in the writing center of your college/university.

The Chicago Manual of Style. University of Chicago Press. 2003.

St. Martin's Handbook. Andrea A. Lunsford. 2009

Butcher's Copy-editing. Judith Butcher. 2006.

Copy-editing: A Practical Guide. Karen Judd. 2001.